

Costa's €2 trillion grand tour

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POLITICO's must-read briefing on what's driving the day in Brussels, by Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur and Gabriel Gavin. By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MOR

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GOOD MORNING. It's Gabriel Gavin back at the helm. Few may be paying attention to the Brussels bubble this week, but there's still plenty going on.

In today's Playbook:

- EU-U.K. talks are back on the agenda with a new British minister.
- The top spots to watch the sunset with a cocktail in Brussels this week.
- Faces in the crowd: Thomas Byrne, Giorgia Meloni, Siegfried Mureșan, Maia Sandu, Princess Mabel of Orange-Nassau, Mark Zuckerberg, Belgian DJ collectives, Hamish Falconer and more.

DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — THE COSTA DOING BUSINESS: European Council President António Costa is launching a charm offensive to prepare the ground for a deal on the EU's biggest-ever seven-year budget by the end of the year.

Wants compromise, will travel: There's growing urgency among the EU's 27 leaders to wrap up negotiations on the €2 trillion Multiannual Financial Framework before the talks can be derailed by national elections next year. And Costa is hitting the road to help get it done.

The Council president is embarking on a tour of EU capitals from Aug. 25, he told Playbook. He'll meet presidents and prime ministers on their home turf to understand "the priorities of Europe's leaders and the citizens they represent," starting with Slovakia before moving up through Central Europe and the Baltics. The only country he'll skip, for now, is Sweden, which has a parliamentary election next month.

Find your wallet: There's still an intractable divide on the MFF between the EU's frugal countries, which want to keep their contributions down, and those eager to get their hands on European cash.

In the frugal corner ... Germany wants hundreds of billions of euros of spending cut from the proposals. The Netherlands branded the "negobox" put forward in June by Cyprus (when it held the presidency of the Council of the EU) as "a no-go box" because of its big spending.

And in the rival camp ... there's the "Friends of Cohesion" alliance, which counts 16 members including Italy, Poland, Greece and Spain. It insists cuts would undermine the European economy and withdraw funding for key sectors at the very moment they most need support.

Ireland, which holds the EU presidency in the second half of this year, will present a new draft budget ahead of a European Council in October, leaving Costa to corral leaders.

Costa's No. 1 priority: The Council president made it clear he knows it's his job to keep the negotiations on track, adding that agreeing the MFF "stands above all others" as the key decision to be taken this year. "It is our collective responsibility to strike the right balance for our Union, our citizens and our future," he said.

The timeline is tight: While the European Council president is confident a deal can be reached before the end of 2026, the consequences of failing to do so could be severe. The European Parliament needs to agree to the terms and national capitals need time to implement legislation to get ready for the new budget. Elections in France, Spain, Greece, Estonia, Italy, Poland and Slovakia could see governments change and opposition politicians push to reopen the negotiations.

There's no indication either side is ready to back down yet. Siegfried Mureşan, the MEP overseeing negotiations for the center-right European People's Party in the Parliament, told Playbook: "We recognize the fiscal constraints facing member states. But if we all agree that competitiveness, security and defense are priorities, we must allocate the necessary resources" and not cut too deep.

Mureşan wants to cement the EU's powers to raise money through its "own resources" — namely bloc-wide taxes. He sees a digital economy levy as the "most promising" option, on top of revenue measures put forward by Commission President Ursula von der Leyen on carbon emissions, tobacco and electronic waste. But whatever the negotiations yield, Parliament will refuse to sign off on a budget without adequate fundraising, he added.

Expect the diplomatic maneuvering to intensify as the year winds down. "The last thing you want to have is a cliff edge and it not be ready in 2028," said one EU official working on the budget. And it could come down to the wire — officials expect October's Council meeting to last two days, with more summits planned in November and December.

BIG AND BREAKING

PATRIOT DUTY: European countries are scrambling to meet Ukraine's increasing demand for U.S.-made Patriot interceptors as it braces for Russian attacks on its critical infrastructure this winter, Chris Lunday and Veronika Melkozerova report.

DRONE DOWN: Russia's war in Ukraine is to blame for a lethal drone that crashed and exploded in a Moldovan village, threatening the lives of residents, Moldova's President Maia Sandu warned .

SPARKS FLY: Greece's aging power grid is causing some of the country's most devastating wildfires , my colleague Nektaria Stamouli reports.

DIGITAL FRONTIER: The EU, Meta and TikTok have agreed to create a new fact-checking channel to stop human traffickers mobilizing people to cross from Morocco into the Spanish exclave of Ceuta, Eliza Gkritsi writes .

POWERFUL QUAKE HITS COLOMBIA: Ursula von der Leyen said the EU has mobilized its Copernicus satellite system to support rescue efforts in Colombia after an earthquake killed at least 132 people .

BRITISH RESET

THE FALCON TAKES FLIGHT: The Irish presidency of the Council of the EU will today open talks with the U.K.'s new European Relations Minister Hamish Falconer, who took office last month in Prime Minister Andy Burnham's government reshuffle. That comes as officials work towards a rescheduled bilateral summit later this year where sides are hoping to reset relations.

Ireland's European Affairs Minister Thomas Byrne told Playbook he is "ambitious to support the strongest possible EU-U.K. relationship because it is in our shared interests, especially when it comes to delivering for business, young people and our security." The long-awaited summit, he went on, "is a chance to strengthen that partnership."

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

MONEY MIRACLE: Germany's churches are losing followers, but they're gaining cash nonetheless. Sonja Rijnen dug into the controversial tax behind the numbers .

BURNHAM'S "BUY BRITISH" TEST: The U.K. government has vowed to back British AI companies to cut its reliance on American technology — but can it get by without Palantir ?

ZUCK SPEAKS: Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg has issued a defense of AI arguing that highly advanced models should be broadly available to drive economic opportunities — but that vision is proving divisive even among tech bosses .

UNUSUAL PAIR: Denmark's center-left Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen and Italy's right-wing leader Giorgia Meloni have teamed up to push for tougher action on illegal migration and the protection of "Europe's Christian cultural heritage."

A LONG WEIGHT: Britain's medicines regulator has approved a second weight-loss pill, while EU patients will have to wait until next year for a decision .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny. High of 26C.

DRINKER ON THE ROOF: Brussels is set for yet another week of warm weather. But instead of enviously scrolling your colleagues' beach posts or eyeing a last-minute train to Ostend, why not live the high life in the European capital by watching the sunset from one of the city's rooftop bars?

Tope: On the 22nd floor of the boujee Hoxton hotel in Botanique, this Mexican-inspired restaurant serves up spiced margaritas and tacos (including some questionable fusion options like hoisin duck), with commanding views over the city center and even a monthly bottomless mimosa brunch on offer.

Lila29: An elegant Spanish speakeasy-style eatery , unashamedly pitched at the Instagram-loving, cash-splashing in-crowd, this 29th-floor venue atop The Standard hotel in the otherwise sparse area around Gare du Nord has one of the best views in Brussels. But expect to pay for it — cocktails can be

as much as €20, grilled calamari comes in at €52 and a porterhouse steak will set you back €59.

Belgian Beer World: Located in the center, this tasting-friendly museum has a rooftop with stunning views of Brussels and 150 types of beer.

Bozar: This Mont des Arts museum's rooftop is offering great views Wednesday through Sunday until Sept. 20, from 4 p.m. to 11 p.m. It's also one of the cheaper spots, with reasonably priced wine and Brussels Beer Project on tap. DJ collectives from Brussels and beyond will "take audiences on musical journeys through jazz, soul, disco, electro, rap and Latin sounds." Pop in before peak times — the lines can get long.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz is preparing to give Germany's intelligence agencies more power to strike back against foreign sabotage in the wake of the Leipzig drone incident.

London: Andy Burnham is back from his summer break — and facing tough questions on prisoner releases, extreme weather and migrant crossings.

Washington PM: Iran's latest demands are compounding Republicans' biggest liability in the midterms : the rising cost of oil.

Playbook came to Brussels in 2015 and changed how this town starts its day. On 17 August it lands in Canberra: a capital with just as many officials and, until now, no daily briefing of its own. Canberra Playbook: free, daily, radically impartial. Subscribe free .

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Markus Buchheit; former MEPs Andrea Bocskor and Marian-Jean Marinescu; Princess Mabel of Orange-Nassau, a POLITICO 28 alum; POLITICO's Andrew McDonald; European Commission's Cristina Torres Castillo; Cornelia Kutterer of Considerati Europe.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producer Dean Southwell.

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